The Biggest Bet in Indian Markets: The Jio Platforms IPO

The story in 60 seconds

Imagine a company that, in ten years, went from *zero customers* to more than **50 crore (500 million) mobile users**. That is more than the entire population of the European Union.

That company is **Jio**, owned by Mukesh Ambani's Reliance Industries. In October 2026, its parent company, **Jio Platforms Limited**, did something it had never done: it invited ordinary people to buy a small slice of itself on the stock market.

Quick facts	**Detail**
What was sold	New shares of Jio Platforms (an "IPO")
Money raised	**₹30,213 crore** (about $3.2 billion)
Price per share	₹1,065 – ₹1,119 (final price: ₹1,119, the top of the range)
Bidding dates	21 – 23 October 2026
Share of company sold	Only about **2.9%**
Company value at that price	About **₹10.3 lakh crore** (~$108 billion)
Previous record	Hyundai Motor India, ₹27,870 crore (2024)
Listing date on stock exchanges	28 October 2026 (BSE and NSE)

It is **India's biggest IPO ever**. And it is a strange kind of record: the company was not short of money, and it sold less than 3% of itself. So why did the whole country, and much of the world's investment community, stop and watch?

How did Jio get here? A short history

2016 – The disruption. Jio launched with free calls and astonishingly cheap mobile data. Before Jio, data in India was a luxury. After Jio, people watched videos, used maps and paid digitally without counting megabytes. Rivals bled money, and the industry consolidated from many players down to essentially **three private operators (Jio, Airtel, Vodafone Idea) plus state-run BSNL**.

2020 – The global stamp of approval. In just a few weeks, Jio Platforms sold about **33% of itself** to marquee investors (Facebook/Meta, Google, KKR, Silver Lake, Abu Dhabi's ADIA and Mubadala, Saudi Arabia's PIF and others), raising roughly **₹1.5 lakh crore (~$20 billion)**. That money helped Reliance become net-debt-free. It also quietly told the world that serious global investors believed in Jio.

2019 onwards – The promise. Mukesh Ambani said Jio and Reliance Retail would head towards stock market listings within five years. The date kept sliding. In August 2025 he named the first half of 2026 as the target, but in the end the public offer only opened in October 2026.

October 2026 – The listing season. The RHP (the detailed offer document) was filed on 14 October, anchor investors bid on 19 October, and the public offer ran from 21 to 23 October.

Who owns Jio Platforms? (Before the IPO)

Owner	**Stake**
Reliance Industries (the promoter)	66.43%
Meta (Facebook) affiliate	9.98%
Google	7.73%
Others (KKR, Silver Lake, ADIA, etc.)	Remaining

After the IPO, Reliance's stake falls slightly because new shares are created, but it **remains firmly in control**. None of the existing big investors sold in this IPO.

How the IPO was conducted: step by step

An IPO is like staging a huge public event. Here is how this one unfolded.

Step 1: Getting permission and filing papers. Jio filed a detailed document with SEBI (India's market regulator). The final version, the *Red Herring Prospectus (RHP)*, explains the business, finances, risks and use of money.

Step 2: Deciding the price range. A "price band" of ₹1,065–₹1,119 was announced. Investors bid within this range. Because the issue is *book-built*, the final price is discovered by demand, and it landed at the top (₹1,119).

Step 3: The anchor round (19 October). Large institutions bid first. They put in over **₹2.5 lakh crore (~$25 billion) of bids for only about $853 million of shares**, with names such as Abu Dhabi Investment Authority, BlackRock and Fidelity among those allocated shares. When that many experts line up, everyone else pays attention.

Step 4: The public offer (21–23 October). Shares were reserved for different groups:

Group	**Who they are**	**Final-day demand (approx.)**
QIBs	Big institutions: mutual funds, insurers, foreign funds	~67x
NIIs	Wealthy individuals / firms bidding larger amounts	~14x
Retail	Ordinary individual investors	~2.8x
Reliance shareholders	A special quota for existing Reliance owners	~7.6x
Employees	Jio/Reliance staff (₹54 per-share discount)	~2.9x
Overall		**about 22x**

(Small differences exist between sources; the overall figure was reported as roughly 21–22 times.)

Step 5: Allotment and listing. Shares are allotted on 26 October, credited to investors' demat accounts on 27 October, and trading is scheduled to begin on **28 October**.

Where is the money going?

This is one of the most surprising facts. It is a **100% fresh issue**: the money goes to Jio Platforms, **not** to Reliance or the earlier investors.

- **Up to ₹27,500 crore (about 91%)** is meant to **repay loans** of Reliance Jio Infocomm, the telecom subsidiary.
- The rest is for general company purposes.

Why was everyone watching? Seven reasons

1. The sheer size

₹30,213 crore beat Hyundai's record. It is also the largest Indian IPO made up *entirely* of new shares.

2. It is a household name

Almost every Indian knows Jio. Few IPOs involve a brand that people touch daily, which is why over **1 crore individual investors applied**, which was reported as a global record for the number of applications to a single IPO.

3. The Ambani factor

Reliance is India's most closely watched business group. Its last public offering of a new company was Reliance Petroleum in 2006, roughly two decades ago. A new Reliance listing is a once-in-a-generation event.

4. A decade-long wait

Investors had been guessing the timing since 2019. Delays only built the suspense.

5. A bellwether for India's market

India had been one of the world's busiest IPO markets, though returns on 2026 IPOs had been underwhelming for many. A hugely successful Jio listing could renew confidence. A weak one could chill the market.

6. Rival companies' share prices could move

At about ₹10.3 lakh crore, Jio is valued near Bharti Airtel's roughly ₹10.9 lakh crore. Analysts expect the listing to set a fresh "yardstick" for the whole telecom sector, and some believe it improves the odds of another round of **mobile tariff hikes** (which would help Jio, Airtel and Vodafone Idea earn more per customer).

7. The future story: AI, cloud, satellites

Jio isn't only a phone company anymore. It is trying to become a digital-and-AI platform, with partnerships including Nvidia on AI infrastructure. Investors weren't only buying the phone business, they were buying the *possibility* of what comes next.

What is Jio actually worth?

Valuation answers the question: *"Is the price fair for what the company earns?"*

Metric (FY26, year to March 2026)	**Jio Platforms**	**Bharti Airtel**
Operating revenue	~₹1.47 lakh crore	~₹2.11 lakh crore
Profit	~₹30,049 crore	~₹33,823 crore
Profit margin	~20.5%	~16%
Price-to-earnings (P/E)	~34x	~37.5x
Net debt vs. earnings (lower is safer)	0.36x	1.36x
Return on capital (RoCE)	~10.8%	~19%

Metric (FY26, year to March 2026)	Jio Platforms	Bharti Airtel
Monthly revenue per user (ARPU), June 2026 quarter	~₹215	~₹264
Active subscribers (Aug 2026)	~50.3 crore (41.7%)	~48.7 crore (40.3%)

How to read this:

- **P/E of 34** means investors pay ₹34 today for every ₹1 of yearly profit. It is a "how much do people trust the future?" number.
- **Jio is slightly cheaper than Airtel** on P/E and carries much less debt.
- But Jio earns **less per customer** (ARPU) and gets a **lower return** on the huge money it has invested. Closing these gaps is what bulls say will lift the share price later.

Bull case (the optimists): Largest subscriber base, low debt, rising tariffs, broadband (AirFiber and JioFiber), enterprise, AI, and a "scarce" listing that big funds want exposure to.

Bear case (the sceptics): Valuation already assumes a lot of future growth, returns on capital are still modest, tariff hikes can't continue forever, competition is intense, and a tiny float (only ~2.9%) can make the share price jumpy.

The competition: who is Jio up against?

Within India

Competitor	Position	Edge / Weakness
Bharti Airtel	Close #2	Higher ARPU, premium customers, Africa business; heavier debt

Competitor	Position	Edge / Weakness
Vodafone Idea (Vi)	#3, struggling	Weakest finances, losing customers, but the government wants a "3+1 players" market to survive
BSNL / MTNL	State-run	Large rural reach but has historically lagged on network quality
Satellite and new players	Entering	See section 10

The dependence trap: Jio's own profits mostly come from mobile (Reuters reported about 90% of revenue tied to the mobile business). The "AI company" story is exciting, but today Jio is still mainly a **telecom company**.

Risks every curious reader should know

1. **Valuation risk:** Paying ~34x earnings means the market is already expecting growth.
2. **Tariff dependence:** Profits rely on mobile prices rising over time, and regulators and customers can push back.
3. **Capital efficiency:** Jio's return on invested capital (~10.8%) is well below Airtel's.
4. **Low free float:** Only ~2.9% of the company is on offer, so a few big buyers or sellers can swing the price.
5. **Lock-in expiry:** Anchor investors' shares unlock after 30 and 90 days, and when locked shares become sellable, prices can wobble.
6. **Parent company effects:** Reliance Industries' shares may behave differently (analysts debated a "holding company discount").
7. **Competition and technology change:** Satellites, AI-driven services and regulation (such as new spectrum rules) can change economics.
8. **Grey-market hype ≠ reality:** The grey market was hinting at roughly a 22% listing gain (around ₹1,365–₹1,370), but this is unofficial and often wrong.

Lessons

Disruption can be a strategy: Jio gave away what rivals sold at a high price and won the market.

1. **Timing is a strategic weapon:** Reliance waited ~7 years after announcing its intent, until the company's profits, debt and valuation story were strong.
2. **Raise money in layers:** Private global investors (2020) → public market (2026) → each step builds credibility.
3. **Signals matter:** Anchor investors' ~₹2.5 lakh crore of bids told retail investors the deal was "institution-approved."
4. **Sell less, keep control:** Selling only ~2.9% raised a record sum without giving up control.
5. **Use a hype event to fix the balance sheet:** The IPO's main job is debt reduction, which is less glamorous but arguably smarter.

Key timeline

Date	**Event**
2016	Jio launches, disrupts mobile data pricing
2019	Ambani says Jio and Retail will list within five years
Apr–Jul 2020	~33% stake sold to Meta, Google, KKR and others for ~₹1.5 lakh crore
Mar 2025	Jio and Airtel sign Starlink distribution deals
Aug 2025	Reliance AGM: IPO targeted for H1 2026
Jun 2026	SpaceX (Starlink's parent) lists in the US
Sep 2026	India approves satellite spectrum rules
14 Oct 2026	RHP filed; price band announced

Date	Event
19 Oct 2026	Anchor round (~₹2.5 lakh crore of bids)
21–23 Oct 2026	Public offer; ~22x subscribed, 1 crore+ applications
26–27 Oct 2026	Allotment and share credit
28 Oct 2026	**Listing on NSE and BSE**

What to watch next

- **Listing day (28 Oct):** Does it list at a premium as the grey market suggests?
- **First month:** Does the price hold when anchor lock-ins open?
- **Next mobile tariff hike:** The clearest test of the "IPO unlocks higher prices" idea.
- **Starlink's final approvals and price.**
- **Jio's ARPU, broadband growth and return on capital.**

Glossary (quick reference)

Term	Plain-English meaning
ARPU	Average revenue per user per month
RoCE	How much profit a company makes on every ₹100 invested in it
P/E	Price you pay per ₹1 of yearly profit
FWA	Fixed wireless access: home internet delivered over the air (e.g., JioAirFiber)
GMP	Grey market premium, an unofficial guess of listing gains

Term	Plain-English meaning
Float	The portion of shares actually available to the public
QIB	Qualified institutional buyer (large professional investors)
Lock-in	Period during which certain investors cannot sell
Spectrum	The invisible radio "highway" that carries mobile/satellite signals

---

Sources

Numbers come from news reports and IPO data sites as of 24 October 2026, and small discrepancies exist between them (e.g., overall subscription 21.4x–22.2x; application count 1 crore+). Please double-check against the exchange (NSE/BSE) and Jio's RHP.

- Finimize / Reuters summary – Jio Platforms' $3.2B IPO
- Outlook Money – Jio IPO sets new benchmarks
- Metro Vaartha – ₹7 lakh crore demand and records
- BigGo Finance – $25B anchor demand
- Chittorgarh – subscription status
- Zerodha – use of proceeds
- Tech Times – RHP and debt repayment
- ICICI Direct – shareholding and IPO overview
- INDmoney – valuation vs Airtel
- IPO Scouter – Jio vs Airtel
- TradingView / Moody's – impact on Airtel, Vi, Indus
- Business Standard – 2020 stake sale to global investors
- Reuters via Yahoo Finance – IPO delay report (2025)
- Beebom – Starlink gateway sites and spectrum rules
- Bloomberg Law – Starlink India approvals
- Advanced Television – SpaceX's denial
- Business Standard – Starlink India pricing report

- Wikipedia – SpaceX IPO
- Policy Circle – Jio and Airtel Starlink partnerships
- IndiaInfoline – GMP trend